

What Roles do Drugs Play in Community Building?



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Historical accounts and ethnographic analogies help archaeologists understand the role that psychoactive drugs may have played in building community in the past. Often, these drugs have been used in both medicine and religious practice, typically by ritual specialists whom we may call priests, healers, or shamans. We know well the role of alcohol and chocolate, both mildly psychoactive, in various communities of the past. A similar role is played in Polynesian societies by the drink kava. This beverage is prepared from *Piper methysticum*, a plant related to black pepper. The roots are used to make a beverage known for its mild sedative properties, which calm and relax drinkers; the kava drinking ritual is an important part of reducing tensions in contentious social interactions, within or between communities. The ritual created around the sharing of this drink with newcomers illustrates its central importance in mediating conflict and building community in Polynesian society.